

Structure is a spectrum, and it decides who does the work

more of the structuring work falls on you



Structured

the file carries the schema

BMS sensor logs, meter readings, CSV exports

Work: validate types, handle missing values

Semi-structured

the file describes itself, but irregularly

JSON, XML, IFC/BIM, GeoJSON

Work: flatten nested records into a table

Unstructured

nothing carries a schema for the payload

work orders, photos, point clouds, PDFs

Work: extract features you choose and define

"Unstructured" does not mean without structure. It means the structure is not in the file, so you must impose it.